Falling

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/54785095.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Suicide Attempt, Suicidal Thoughts, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Post-Canon, Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Heavy Angst, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Post-War

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Falling

by moonfreeze

Summary

It’s always the same dream; falling.

Adora keeps dreaming of letting herself fall off her room’s balcony.

She always knows it’s just a dream. And each time, she uncurls her fingers and falls. The sky is always stormy. Sometimes it even rains. Rarely, it’s sunny but the sun never lasts long.

She wakes up when she hits the ground, something akin to temptation filling her bones. It’s a very dry and aching kind of temptation. And it’s pointless anyway, so she ignores it.

Adora thought she made a choice.

Turns out she made a mistake instead.

Notes

here, have some messy angst soup *passes bowl*

It’s always the same dream; *falling.*

Adora keeps dreaming of letting herself fall off her room’s balcony.

She always knows it’s just a dream. And each time, she uncurls her fingers and *falls.* The sky is always stormy. Sometimes it even rains. Rarely, it’s sunny but the sun never lasts long.

She wakes up when she hits the ground, something akin to temptation filling her bones. It’s a very dry and aching kind of temptation. And it’s pointless anyway, so she ignores it.

She ignores the dreams up until she’s left alone on the balcony. Her fingers are gripping the railing. Her knuckles turn white and she stares down at the ground.

She could just-.

She didn’t. She wouldn’t.

If you fight a war all your life, who do you become without it? Without the throbbing of your joints, without blood smeared over your clothes, without bandages dumped in a trashcan, without purpose?

Light Hope was right, in a way. She-Ra was a weapon. And there’s no use for a weapon when all battles have already been won. It was getting harder to summon the sword. The missing weight of

the sword had felt like a throbbing longing on her fingers for too long.

Glimmer put her off duty. *Recovery time-off,* she had said.

Adora knew she hadn't been herself for a long time. The old Adora knew how to laugh, knew how to breathe without drowning and smile without pain. She didn't. She didn't know anything anymore.

Catra took her to the garden a lot. She thought the plants could help cheer her up because nothing else was working. They drank tea and she could feel Catra's worried gaze burning into her far more painfully than any nightmare. She felt Catra gently hold her hand as if trying to say *I'm here, please keep trying.*

Those words never really registered. Had they ever? Wasn't there a point in her life where the only thing she couldn't stop herself from wanting was for Catra to join her and stay? Catra is here, isn't she? And Adora was glad she was here. So why did everything feel so numb and scattered still?

A few months after the war had ended, Adora hadn't begun to feel this tiredness. She'd run around on other planets, trying to bring magic back to them. She was happy, even if there was always a cold rod pressed against her heart as she tried to go to sleep and the nightmares grew frequent.

The feeling grew worse on Etheria, especially in her bedroom in Brightmoon. She helped with repairs until she could. She was losing her grip on She-Ra.

(She ended up in the infirmary after overworking, a strange grief taking over her whole self. She felt the tears build up in her eyes. They only poured at night, when no one was watching. For the first time in years, she sobbed as she clung on to her pillow.)

Catra would hold her every night, wake her up from any nightmares and gently whisper reassurances into her ear as her heart raced. Adora knew how hard she was trying to help. Her

voice seemed to take on a new note of carefulness and softness around her, as if she was afraid of hurting her. Adora wanted to feel angry at that but she couldn't. She couldn't feel anything.

(She talked to Perfuma once.

"I think," Perfuma said, handing her a flower. "You're experiencing post-traumatic stress disorder."

The term passed over her head, as did everything else these days. She held the flower and crushed it when she was alone in her room again, letting the petals fall to the ground.

Was it wrong to say she missed the war? Even if she couldn't sleep because of it? Why did she miss the war if it just hurt-?)

Adora didn't mind the dream, really. Of falling down her balcony. She didn't know why. It felt comforting, almost.

Everything felt drowned these days. Like color had left her world, every dye of reality mixing in until all that's left is black. Everyone else and their voices seemed far away as if her mind was taking her prisoner. So, she watched and listened as much as she could.

Not all days were this bad. There were moments where she the anxiety building up in her gut dissipated and her mind found something new to focus on. It was rare, but the pain finally faded away in those moments. Black turned to white. These brief minutes weren't enough though. They would never be. She looked forward to them, tried to tell herself this feeling would end. In the end, it always returned.

Even eating had become hard. She used to love scarfing down food. Now? The second she ate, she almost threw it back up again.

And there were worse days too. When she couldn’t bring herself to get up and walk around the castle or sit in the gardens. Her mind would betray her again and tears would pour out of her eyes while she shook with silent sobs.

And again, Catra would comfort her.

Wasn’t it supposed to be the other way around? Catra was the one who suffered more, right? She even *died*. And Adora was always supposed to comfort *her.* The thought made her feel suffocated. Like a fish on land. Adora wasn't *supposed* to be comforted like she was made of glass.

Adora never experienced the brunt of the war. So why was this feeling consuming her until there was nothing left but black in her world?

She wanted to ease the worry and fear in Catra’s eyes. They always seemed to beg the answer to one question she herself couldn’t ask.

Are you going to get better?

Adora didn’t know the answer, even as she entered their room to Catra’s eyes watering and her mouthing the words *I just want you to be okay. I don’t know how.*

Everyone knew Adora was getting worse. Could she blame Catra for being terrified?

A new wave of guilt plagued her for the next few days.

And now Adora's back, still clutching at the balcony railing. She lets her thoughts materialize, gripping harder and harder as they got worse.

There was a simple truth that spilled out. Adora was useless. She couldn't get better and she couldn't work or fight. And, she was *tired.* Of waking up each day with a pit in her heart only growing into a wider chasm.

The sky was dark grey, covered in thick clouds just like in the dreams. Only this time, she's wide awake, living the dream that would let her die.

She almost wishes she would've been disintegrated at the Heart. She would've made Catra go back, run as far away as possible. She would've died with the war.

Her hands are shaking now and it isn't from the cold.

Adora makes a choice. A last choice. This one choice, she'll allow herself to have.

She lifts herself onto the railing and sits, letting the rain patter against her face. It doesn't strike her that she never said goodbye to anyone. Her hair is loose and getting wetter with every second. It almost feels good. Her breath is shaky against the wind and she decides she won't cry this time. There's one last piece of her will left and she'll gladly use it.

Adora let herself fall.

She knew this time she wouldn't wake up when she hit the ground.

Only, she never hit the ground. She didn't fall either. A hand grabbed and pulled at her own, another digging and gripping onto her shirt with claws she could recognize anywhere.

When she gets pulled up, her will falls apart and she cries, looking at the broken and horrified look on Catra's face. Her eyes are wide and pupils so narrow as she stares at Adora in a terrible shock. Her hands are still locked on Adora. They crumple on the floor, unable to speak.

She thought she made a choice.

Now she thinks she made a mistake instead.

But of course, the chasm still grows wider and the colors still continue to fade to black.

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